

Democracy

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Abstract

The study of democracy, how it emerged, when it survives, and when it dies, is a preeminent concern for a great many scholars, as well as for the broader public. Here I review three classic questions about democracy involving its deep origins, the advent of universal adult suffrage, and the varied success with sustaining modern electoral democracy. I do so by considering recent work in historical political economy and how it contributes to earlier work in political science, economics, and history. In an era where democracy faces significant challenges, it is all the more important to consider what its long history can tell us about the present. Democracy is a robust form of governance that many different human societies have practiced. Even so, democracy in an individual country can never be taken from granted and maintaining it requires both periodic institutional creativity and continual investment so as to better connect citizens to the state.

There could hardly be a more central question to political science than asking how, when, and why democracy thrives and when it fails. In recent years scholars in the field of historical political economy have made important progress in helping us answer this question. In what follows I am going to proceed in three steps, first focusing on the deep origins of modern democracy in Europe and what this can tell us about democracy today. Then I will examine the history of universal suffrage as a core element of modern democracy. Finally, I will ask when and why the principle that differences be settled through free and fair elections is sometimes respected and sometimes not. I will survey a broad variety of contributions using different methodologies. Some of this will involve empirical work focused on causal identification while other work will be more suggestive and descriptive, providing what Sean Gailmard (2021) has called “candidate explanations” for further study.

Democracy is a form of governance that has existed in a great many human societies, arguably stretching across multiple continents and far back in time.¹ For the Greeks the concept of *demokratia* meant simply that the people ruled or that the people had power. This is a definition that does not refer to a specific set of institutions, even though in Athens it had a particular manifestation with the participation of all classes—with the prominent exception of women and slaves—in the assembly, the *ekklesia*, combined with the right for all to hold office. Many societies outside the Greek world also had assemblies and councils for governance, and in these, particularly at the local level, participation could quite broad and sometimes could involve participation by women. The key feature of these early democracies—both inside and outside the Greek world—was that participation was most commonly direct rather than being indirect through representatives.

The deep origins of modern democracy involve first the development of representative assemblies in medieval Europe, a phenomenon that many scholars in historical political economy have considered. The key questions here are how this happened, and why it happened in Europe first as opposed to other world regions. Europeans did not invent collective governance—that was practiced by many societies—but they did succeed in developing a form of political representation that could operate at scale. Asking how and why this happened is not only of historical interest; it may also help tell us something about the foundations of democracy even today and its future prospects.

Modern democracy is a system where citizens elect representatives via universal suffrage. A broad (though not yet universal) suffrage—for free white males—emerged first in the United States before spreading elsewhere. The story of this spread, and its expansion to include previously excluded groups, has been a principal area of focus for scholars in historical political economy. Recent work suggests that rather than being

¹ In Stasavage (2020) I make the case for the existence of early democracy among many societies. For a different view see Cartledge (2016). Carles Boix (2015) has written on the variety of political regimes in early states.

something that emerged because it was a commitment to redistribute, universal suffrage has advanced in many cases because elites have learned that they can find ways to live with it without fearing losing their wealth. Today universal suffrage has become such a strong norm that even those who seek to mute its effect feel compelled to suggest that they are only trying to make the suffrage more secure. Scholarship in historical political economy helps show us how the principle of universal suffrage emerged and took root.

Together with universal suffrage, modern democracy involves elections with multiple political parties, and it is sometimes described as a system where incumbents can actually lose.² The notion that someone would hold power and then be willing to give it up is not something to be taken for granted. The question then becomes when and where this is more likely to take place. Recent work in historical political economy calls into question the idea that there is an inevitable causal link between a country's level of per capita gross domestic product and the likelihood that electoral democracy will flourish. The survival of democracy may depend more on the presence of civil society organizations, institutionalized political parties, and also finally on efforts by the state itself to make investments such as educating the citizenry.

Representative Assemblies

The deep origins of modern democracy lie in the representative assemblies of medieval and early modern Europe. The simple fact that so many current parliaments bear the names of their medieval forebears shows this quite clearly. But why did this happen in Europe and not elsewhere, why at this time, and how was it accomplished? We should not say here that Western Europe was unique in having representatives, because other societies, from the Wendat (Huron) in what is now Ontario to the Ashanti in what is now Ghana, also sent individuals to central assemblies. However, the sheer number of parliaments that emerged in Europe remains something to be explained, as does the ability of Europeans to construct parliaments that drew representatives from vast territories. While Europeans established assemblies that allowed for societal participation in governance—particularly for elites—this was a system that excluded women.³ In the next section we will need to ask why this changed so dramatically in the case of women with the eventual adoption of universal adult suffrage.

² This succinct definition derives from the minimalist definition of democracy proposed by Adam Przeworski et al. (2000). A more expansive definition of democracy, proposed by Robert Dahl (1998 [2020] p.38) emphasizes five criteria: (1) “effective participation,” meaning that all members must have equal opportunities for influence, and presumably not only through voting (2) “voting equality” (3) “enlightened understanding” meaning that each member has an opportunity to learn about policies and their consequences, (4) “control of the agenda,” meaning that the members have the exclusive right to decide, and (5) inclusion of all adults.

³ Europeans were not unique in this regard, but governance in a number of different non-European societies did allow for women to play a role in politics. See Stasavage (2020) on the examples of the

There is clear evidence that the threat of war and actual outbreaks of war favored the development of representative assemblies in medieval and early modern Europe, and the literature on this topic is lengthy, dating back to the classic political science contributions by Levi (1988) and Bates and Lien (1985). Gary Cox, Mark Dincecco, and Massimiliano Onorato (2021) provide one of the most recent and complete econometric assessments of the role of warfare in leading to the rise of European parliaments.⁴ In doing so they follow the standard assumption that war incidence prompted representative assemblies to emerge because of the need for revenue. However, they also make another telling point; assembly emergence was also dependent on the presence of communes—cities and towns that enjoyed a substantial amount of autonomy to manage their own affairs—because it was the communes who played a major role in providing resources to monarchs. They argue therefore that the presence of communes was a necessary enabling condition for representative assemblies to emerge.

The European data appear to support the idea that autonomous cities and parliaments were the product of a process of urban agglomeration as part of the Commercial Revolution of the Middle Ages, a phenomenon that began in the eleventh century and which lasted until the Black Death.⁵ When we look at urbanization cross regionally, though, we need to recognize that medieval China also had a commercial revolution, yet it led to a very different political outcome. Instead of strengthening society with respect to the state, the opposite took place as the existing Chinese bureaucratic state moved to tax commerce and as merchants used their capital to invest in education that gave their offspring a better chance of passing China's civil service exam for entry into the bureaucracy.⁶ Under the Song dynasty, state revenues as a share of GDP exceeded those in medieval France and England by an order of magnitude.⁷ This is indicative of a very strong state.

The contrast between China and Western Europe suggests that something else was afoot apart from the simple facts of war and commercial growth. I have argued that representative assemblies flourished in Medieval Europe because its rulers lacked the sort of strong state bureaucracies that would have allowed them to tax commerce without the need for agreeing to a consensual form of governance like a representative

Wendat (Huron) and Haudenosaunee (Iroquois). See Achebe (2005) on the political role of women in precolonial Igbo land.

⁴ For other recent work see Magalhaes and Giovannoni (2019).

⁵ See Abramson and Boix (2019) for a broader view of the link between urban agglomeration in Europe and the rise of parliaments.

⁶ See Chen and Kung (2021) on this development. See also the important recent work by Yuhua Wang (2022a, 2022b) on the links between the Chinese examination system, elite lineage ties, and the construction of the Chinese state.

⁷ See Stasavage (2020) p.12 and Guo (2019) for more details on the Chinese revenue data across several dynasties.

assembly. More generally, the extreme weakness of bureaucracies in medieval Europe meant that princely rulers of territorial states had to govern collectively with members of society, albeit with a very elite version of society.

There is an important lesson we can draw for today based on this comparison of China and Western Europe: sequencing matters. If collective governance is your goal, then it helps to have it develop first before a powerful state bureaucracy emerges. Other authors have recently provided evidence of this phenomenon (Gjerlow et al. 2021). Jørgen Møller (2015) makes a similar point with respect to European state development over the long run. If, on the other hand, a bureaucratic state emerges prior to the establishment of collective governance, then it will be more difficult to develop democracy. This is something that important work by Lisa Blaydes (2017) has established for the modern Middle East.

The emergence of European parliaments did not only depend on a particular geopolitical and bureaucratic environment; it also required institutional creativity. As Anna Grzymala Busse shows in her forthcoming book, much of the technology to make a representative assembly work—in terms of core guiding principles—was first developed within the Catholic Church.⁸ Accounts of European assemblies date back to the famous account by Tacitus written around the turn of the first century of the common era.⁹ But these were assemblies where people spoke for themselves. The problem medieval Europeans faced was how to organize an assembly with representatives. In the case of nobles or bishops, attending an assembly was relatively straightforward—they already, in theory, spoke for a region or diocese. But what of the inhabitants of a city who also desired some form of representation that did not depend on the whim of a bishop or knight? The solution here—echoing an innovation in the church—was to think of a city as a fictitious person, and here again the inspiration for this was a prior practice from the medieval church, an idea which is said to have come from the notion from Saint Augustine that after Peter received the keys to the church, he signified the Holy Church (Tierney, 1982).

One of the final intellectual innovations from the medieval era was an evolution that took place within the English parliament: the disappearance of mandates for representatives. One singular feature of modern democracy—something that has been agreed on since the ratification of the United States Constitution as well as the French Revolution—is that barring illegal behavior, the only way in which representatives can be sanctioned, controlled, or disciplined is at the ballot box. In most early European assemblies the situation was very different; towns that sent representatives to a meeting

⁸ See Anna Grzymala Busse (2022). Historians, such as Brian Tierney (1982), have also placed a heavy emphasis on the Catholic Church as a sort of laboratory in which principles of representation developed. See Schwartzberg (2014) on voting procedures in assemblies and their churchly origins, in particular with regard to supramajority rules.

⁹ Tacitus *Germania* (Penguin Classics edition)

sought to bind these individuals by issuing strict instructions regarding what could or could not be agreed to. This was the case with the Cortes of Castile, the Estates General of the Netherlands, and numerous other assemblies. While this helped provide a degree of security for constituents, it also made for unwieldy decision making that continually frustrated monarchs. The English Parliament proved to be an exception to this rule. By the middle of the fourteenth century a norm was established that representatives in the House of Commons should debate and decide without being bound by mandates from their constituents and without the possibility of referring back to their constituents for further instructions. The reasons why this transformation took place are not entirely clear, though they may relate to the fact that dating back to Anglo Saxon times, English monarchs were in a relatively strong position with respect to local elites, or at least a stronger position when compared with other European monarchs.¹⁰ With its absence of mandates the English Parliament provided an example that would subsequently be followed by all modern democracies.

Universal Suffrage

Unlike earlier forms of collective governance, which often had restrictive participation, modern democracy requires that there be universal suffrage. The question of how this practice emerged has stimulated a very substantial amount of work in historical political economy. While most of this work has focused on the advent of universal male suffrage, in recent years scholars have focused on the question of how the suffrage was also extended to women and racial minorities.

The most common story of how universal suffrage is established involves a distributional struggle where those with wealth end up conceding the vote to those without and the policy outcome is then greater economic redistribution.¹¹ For scholars who follow this approach, the question is then what factors might prompt a transition from a limited suffrage of the sort that many European countries practiced in the nineteenth century towards universal access to the vote. While it is hard to deny the reality and importance of class conflict over the suffrage, particularly in the Western European cases, subsequent empirical work has raised important questions about the distributional argument. Take the canonical English case; the reform acts of 1832 and 1867 did not result in significant redistribution, at least by twentieth century standards, nor was it apparent that the poorer members of society voted for the political parties that

¹⁰ Chris Wickham (1997) suggests that circa 1000 CE Anglo-Saxon England was arguably the sole society in Western Europe, outside of Arab controlled Spain, that was able to maintain a system of direct taxation of agriculture. In an important recent book, Deborah Boucoyannis (2021) has also emphasized the ability to English monarchs to compel local elites to take certain actions.

¹¹ Following the classic work of Acemoglu and Robinson (2000) and Boix (2003) as well as Przeworski (2008) and Aidt and Franck (2015) this was conceived in terms of a distributional struggle where the key issue is who gets taxed, and by how much, and who receives redistributive benefits.

the distributional argument would predict, nor is it even clear that the 1832 act was principally about redistribution at all.¹²

What if instead of conceding the suffrage as a commitment to redistribute wealth, elites gradually learned that this would not be the outcome? The flipside of the distributional argument for suffrage extensions is that elites eventually accepted universal suffrage because over time they learned that they had less to fear from it than they initially believed. Evidence from government bond markets—a very large source of elite wealth at this time—allows us to look at this learning mechanism more directly. In an important pair of articles Aditya Dasgupta and Daniel Ziblatt (2021, 2018) have shown that initial suffrage extensions, such as that which occurred in the United Kingdom in 1832, led to large spikes in yields on government bonds—a prime asset for wealth holders at the time. Over time, with subsequent suffrage extensions these spikes grew less and less pronounced: there was less fear about extending the suffrage. This does not mean that the suffrage had no redistributive consequences—Dasgupta and Ziblatt certainly do not say this—but in my opinion their evidence suggests how elites learned that they could live with it without suffering the drastic consequences that some had initially feared.

Outside of Western Europe we see a related phenomenon where elites learned to live with the suffrage because they were able to take the step of reducing state capacity in order to blunt the effect of this reform. In India, elites strengthened their position by reducing state tax collecting capacity in advance of suffrage reforms (Suryanarayan, 2022). The recent article by Suryanarayan and White (2021) provides evidence of a very similar phenomenon in the American South during Reconstruction as white elites were able to blunt the impact of suffrage granted to former slaves by hollowing out the state. The lesson would again seem to be that there were ways that elites could learn to live with the suffrage.

There is a further twist on the redistributive model for the origins of universal manhood suffrage, and this brings war mobilization into the picture. The idea here is that if the masses are going to be expected to fight in a war, then they would demand redistribution in exchange (Ticchi and Vindigni, 2008). The problem with this argument is that it again relies on the assumption that the extension of the suffrage represents a commitment to redistribute. In practice, the European evidence may

¹² See Berlinski and Dewan (2011) on voting patterns following the Second Reform Act as well as Berlinski, Dewan, and Van Coppenolle (2014) for the limited consequences of franchise extension for the British aristocracy. Scheve and Stasavage (2016) provide evidence on the limited effect of suffrage extensions on top rates of income and inheritance taxation. Scheve and Stasavage (2017) provide evidence on top wealth shares and the suffrage. Cox, Fresh, and Saiegh (2021) present evidence to suggest that the motivation for the Great Reform Act of 1832 on the part of the Whigs was to constrain the executive. Recent work by Erik Bengtsson (2021, 2019) suggests that beyond the suffrage, we need to consider complementary forms of mobilization involving popular meetings to understand when and where significant equalizing change took place.

support an alternative version of this argument that does not rely on a promise of redistribution. The idea here would be simply that if men were subject to universal conscription, then they felt that they should have the right to vote, or as the Swedish social democrats said, “one man, one gun, one vote.” The European evidence shows quite a strong relationship whereby passage of a universal conscription law, irrespective of whether a war is underway, is a strong predictor of the subsequent adoption of male universal suffrage.¹³

If we step outside of the redistributive model, then there is a further alternative explanation for the expansion of the suffrage that those who do historical political economy have spent less time considering. Maybe universal suffrage was simply a very compelling idea, and therefore it diffused rapidly? As the historian Jonathan Israel has recently shown, events like the establishment by the state of Pennsylvania of something akin to universal male suffrage, had a very clear impact on thinkers in Europe.¹⁴ It is hard to question the fact that universal suffrage is an appealing principle. In the end, though, it would be equally hard to believe that the idea alone carried the day because it would be a long time before universal suffrage was established in Europe, to say nothing of the continued racial restrictions on the suffrage in the United States and the general exclusion of women from the suffrage.

While the literature on historical political economy has dwelt very extensively on the question of how male universal suffrage first emerged, it is fair to say that achievement of female suffrage has received less attention. The same can be said for the removal of suffrage restrictions based on race. Unlike with universal male suffrage, it seems hard to make the case that the expansion of the suffrage to women was driven by the anticipation of war or by wartime mobilization. It is true that a number of countries did expand the suffrage to women in the wake of the two world wars, but this was true both for war participants and for countries that had remained neutral.¹⁵

Two recent histories of how women gained the right to vote, one by Dawn Teele (2018) and the other by Corinne McConaughy (2014) suggest that the forces that led to female suffrage were quite different than those that have been proposed for male suffrage. In an environment where there was already significant electoral competition, Dawn Teele shows that existing political parties were willing to advocate for female suffrage when they thought that it would benefit them electorally.¹⁶ Relatedly, Corinne McConaughy shows that the adoption of female suffrage in the United States

¹³ I discuss this in more detail in Stasavage (2020) pp.265-268.

¹⁴ See Israel (2027 p.8). The Pennsylvania constitution of 1776 stipulated that adult males who paid taxes had a right to vote irrespective of how much or how little wealth they owed. As the constitution did not state that black citizens did not benefit from this right, many availed themselves of the opportunity, although often with no small amount of personal risk. The Pennsylvania Constitutional Convention of 1838 stipulated that black citizens did not have the right to vote.

¹⁵ See the analysis in Teele (2018).

¹⁶ See also the survey by Teele and Grosjean (2022) in this volume.

depended on coalition politics and partisan maneuvering, rather than being solely the work of great crusaders like Susan B. Anthony. Beyond investigating the existence of absence of the female suffrage, one other area upon which work in historical political economy might focus would involve examining the ways in which women sought to play political roles in the absence of having the suffrage, such as in participating in campaign rallies and events. Historians have considered this for the Antebellum United States.¹⁷

The broader question raised by the contributions by Teele (2018) and McConaughy (2014) is that if the timing of the extension of the suffrage to women ended up depending on what might call “ordinary” electoral politics concerns, then why did this not happen until the early part of the twentieth century? One possibility is that once there was universal suffrage for men, the existence of this principle increased the ability of other groups to stake a similar claim. Still, it is interesting that in a country like the United States, the Whig party was active in trying to enlist women to participate in rallies as early as the 1840 presidential campaign, but it would take a considerably longer time before major parties accepted female suffrage.

The story of African American suffrage in the United States has been quite different from either suffrage for white males or white women. The extent of African American suffrage has ebbed and flowed over time in response to changing political conditions. We saw already above that after in theory enfranchising free African Americans in 1776, the State of Pennsylvania withdrew this right some sixty-two years later. Recent historical political economy scholarship has provided a new view of the effects of voter suppression in the American South. Using extensive data from the State of Louisiana, Keele, Cubbison, and White (2021) chart the early rise of voter registration for African Americans after the Civil War and the dramatic decline after the imposition of poll taxes and literacy requirements after 1898. Subsequent institutional innovations such as the “understanding clause” of the 1950s served to suppress the African American vote even after poll taxes were abolished. Chacon, Jensen, and Yntiso (2021) show how during Reconstruction, African American voting was supported by the direct presence of US Federal Troops, which soon disappeared.¹⁸ If for the vast majority of countries, the extension of the franchise to all adult men and then all adult women was an absorbing state, the story of African American suffrage in the United States has been anything but that.

Rather than propose such a clear violation of the principle of universal suffrage, as was done in the American South, other governments have used subterfuge. Daniel Gingerich has shown how the introduction of the Australian Ballot in Brazil led to an (intended) reduction in voter turnout because this method of voting proved more

¹⁷ Work by historians such as Arendt (2020) and Varon (1995) has considered this in the context of the Antebellum United States.

¹⁸ See also David Bateman (2019) on the broader case of democratic disenfranchisement.

difficult for those unable to read (Gingerich 2019). In short, universal adult suffrage has become an idea that is so compelling that for the most part, the only way you can undermine it is to use various artifices and in doing so say that you are actually taking steps to support the suffrage by making it more secure.¹⁹

While the right to vote is critical for modern democracy to function, we should also acknowledge that there are forms of political participation other than voting that can prove critical to the health of a democracy. In an important recent book, Daniel Carpenter (2021), has provided extensive evidence to suggest that the health of democracy in the Early Republic and Antebellum eras in the United States depended critically on the growth of petitions to Congress as a way for citizens to express their preference. Petitioning allowed for the expression of specific views in a frequent manner which helped because elections occur only episodically. In practice, it was also something that was used by those who did not yet have the right to vote: women, free African Americans, and sometimes also indigenous groups. Future work in historical political economy might do more to ask when and where these forms of non-electoral participation have strengthened democracy.

Elections With Alternation

Along with universal suffrage, the companion principle of modern democracy is that political differences are settled through competitive elections in which incumbents sometimes lose. Today, while the norm of universal adult suffrage is generally taken as granted, that the loser respects the outcome of a competitive election is a much less certain thing. What have we learned of late regarding how this system is actually sustained?

While there is no shortage of explanations on offer, perhaps the most prominent has been that a country's level of economic development—or sometimes its level of modernity more generally—is the best predictor of whether electoral democracy is sustainable.²⁰ As with many arguments about democracy, the initial impetus for this argument came from European evidence: as Europe grew rich it democratized. One of the things often overlooked in this literature—where modernization is generally proxied by GDP per capita—is that if we want to understand why a region like Western Europe is universally democratic today, then instead of looking at contemporary correlations, we ought to consider how rich or poor European countries were when they first democratized, and if we do this, then we see, for example, that France in 1870 at the

¹⁹ The rare exception here would be the case of a current political theorist, Jason Brennan (2016), who has advocated an “epistocracy” where the votes of those who are better informed count more.

²⁰ The modern literature on this question began with Lipset (1959), and some of the most notable contributions have been Przeworski et al. (2000), Boix and Stokes (2003), Boix (2011), and Acemoglu, Johnson, Robinson, and Yared (2009).

outset of the Third Republic had the same level of per capita income that Tanzania does today.²¹ Nor did it have any of the accoutrements of modernity emphasized by Lipset (1959) such as telephones, radios, or televisions. If the first great wave of democratization took place in a set of countries that were quite poor by today's standards, then we may need to look elsewhere for an explanation.

Recent work in historical political economy suggests, based on within country evidence, several new directions for considering the link between economic modernization and democracy. It does so by going beyond investigating the correlation between democracy and levels of per capita GDP. Using evidence from the United Kingdom, Adriane Fresh (2018) shows how industrialization fostered increased competition in parliamentary elections by diversifying the portfolios of MPs. Using cross-country evidence, Sam van Noort (2021) has found evidence of a correlation between the size of the manufacturing sector and democracy, which he suggests is significant because this economic transformation made it easier for the working class to mobilize. This is an argument that Seymour Martin Lipset himself would have certainly recognized, but it has not been given an airing in some time. The lesson of all this work would seem to be that there may indeed be a link between economic modernization and democracy, but it may not be found in the place that most people have been looking.

If many scholars point to potential deep determinants of democracy, such as culture and economic development, whether a democracy survives or dies may also depend upon short-term decisions made by political elites. The current political context, especially in the United States but also in Europe, has prompted some scholars to look to the interwar period. This has most famously been done by Steven Levitsky and Daniel Ziblatt (2017) who point to the importance of decisions made by political elites, particularly on the right, in a polarized environment, asking whether traditional conservatives ally themselves with extremists and their strategies. Their conclusions here rely on a deep vein of historical research.²²

While the interwar period is most often used as an example of behavior to be avoided, in an insightful recent book, Cornell, Møller, and Skanning (2020) remind us that in spite of the massive economic dislocations of the interwar period—shocks that make the Great Recession and the COVID pandemic seem small—the large majority of established democracies survived the interwar period quite well. They show this using evidence from both Europe and the Americas. They suggest that three factors were critically important in sustaining democracy during this difficult era. The first, perhaps not surprisingly, was whether a country had an extensive democratic history. The second factor was the presence of strong civil society organizations, and the third was the presence of institutionalized political parties. These conditions helped prevent a transition to authoritarian rule.

²¹ This is based on data from the Maddison Project.

²² See in particular Ziblatt (2018).

It is also possible that mass education has helped to sustain electoral democracy, though we need to be careful to ask how exactly this might happen. One of the fears expressed by political elites in the Early Republic in the United States was that ordinary citizens might opt out of trying to achieve their goals through the electoral process and instead resort to violent revolt. These fears were kindled in particular by Shays Rebellion of 1786 and by the Whiskey Rebellion of 1794.²³ These fears may not have been unfounded given the very low turnout rates that prevailed for federal elections in the republic's first years.²⁴

One of the responses by elites to these two crises—apart from suppressing them by force—was to consider how increased basic education provision might be used to mold citizens into active democratic participants. The cross-country political economy literature on democracy and education generally finds it difficult to show that education, particularly if measured in years, solidifies democracy.²⁵ One reason for this may be that children sitting in schools in different countries are learning very different things. In recent work Agustina Paglayan (2022, 2021) has shown that historically, many autocratic governments have also promoted education, and they have done so with the goal of creating obedient populations. Recent within-country evidence from (Paulsen et al. 2022) points to a different effect for democracies such as the Early Republic in the United States. In this instance increased provision of basic schooling—with a particular emphasis on democratic civic duty—was associated with a significant increase in voter turnout from very low initial levels.²⁶ This may have helped to solidify American democracy. Taking the contributions by Paglayan and Paulsen et al. together, we see support for a principle espoused by Aristotle: if you seek to maintain a particular type of political regime, then the format of education should be tailored to that type of political regime (*Politics* VIII:1).

One final point that should be made with respect to elections is that while they are synonymous with modern democracy, scholars in historical political economy ought to continue to study other systems of democratic governance as they existed in the past given that our current institutions may need to evolve. Bernard Manin (1997) famously showed that the principle of elections, as opposed to choosing those who rule by lot, was not an inevitable consequence of trying to practice democracy at scale. It was instead motivated by the notion that elections led to better outcomes. Recently, the

²³ See Condon (2015) on the context for Shays Rebellion and the responses that it prompted as well as Kaestle (1983) p.5 on the idea of investing in common schooling to help prevent future actions of this type. See Rasmussen (2021) for the ideas of John Adams regarding using education to promote “virtue” among the citizenry.

²⁴ See the evidence in the Statistical History of the American Electorate.

²⁵ Acemoglu, Johnson, Robinson, and Yared (2005) were perhaps the first to show that cross-country cross-sectional correlations between education and democracy disappear once one adopts a difference in differences design.

²⁶ This dramatic rise in turnout was emphasized in a classic piece by Burnham (1965).

political theorist, Hélène Landemore (2020), has explored how older forms of political selection based on sortition might be used to construct a more open form of democracy. More historical work that would look back at systems of collective governance as they have existed over the millennia could help shed light on possibilities for reform today. Alexandra Cirone (2019a) has recently produced a very useful survey suggesting exactly how this work might be done for the case of lottery-based procedures for decision making.²⁷ If in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries a number of democracies experimented with alternative forms before settling on the current model, in the twenty-first century, perhaps we ought to be open to the idea that further experimentation is needed in order to give ordinary citizens a better sense of feeling connected to the state.

Conclusion

The emergence of modern democracy has been a very long process. While the quantitative political science work of twenty years ago often focused for reasons of data constraints on developments since the Second World War, more recent work in the field of historical political economy shows us what can be learned from going back in time. This has enabled us to understand more about deep determinants involving the relative balance of power between state and society, something that in Europe allowed for representative government to flourish and expand in a way that did not happen in China. It has also allowed us to understand the history of the suffrage, and how the principle of universal suffrage came to be such a powerful idea. Scholars in historical political economy are approaching this question with a renewed emphasis, and it is one that is rightly focusing on the question of how previously disadvantaged groups were able to use the principle of universal suffrage to gain a voice. Finally, in an era of what many are calling democratic backsliding, where some democracies that previously were thought stable suddenly seem threatened, looking to the past can help us better understand how real these fears should be, and also perhaps also how democratic breakdown can be avoided.

Looking further to the future, if democracy of one form or another has been around for a very long time in a great number of societies, we can probably have confidence that this will continue to be a common way in which some humans govern themselves. Democracy is not like a torch that will fail in general because it is extinguished in one place. But this does not necessarily mean that any individual democracy will continue to survive. One of the principal lessons of this chapter is that sustaining collective governance periodically requires institutional creativity. This has been clear ever since the medieval era when Europeans—aided heavily by members of the church—developed a technology for political representation that could operate at scale. In our

²⁷ See also Cirone (2019b).

current moment with fears of democratic backsliding it is perhaps a time to be creative anew. The second lesson of this chapter for the future is that maintaining a modern democracy also requires investments by the state, and one thinks in particular of education. The goal here is not simply to see that people are educated in some general sense. It is to see that they are educated in a way that encourages people to participate in and sustain democracy by following an agreed set of norms.

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